TRIFECTA
Mind Body Soul

TRIFECTA ADDICTION AND MENTAL HEALTH SERVICES PROGRAM

There are many modalities and programs of addiction recovery. Many of these propositions are unfounded and lack long-term success. Yet these modalities and programs have not been fully mapped out; their existence and diversity have not been broadly communicated to service professionals in Canada, let alone the general population.

The 12-step program of Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) is the best known of such recovery frameworks due to its historical longevity, membership size, widespread accessibility, and influence on Canadian models of addiction treatment, as well as its adaptation to address a long list of other human problems. AA's dominance as a spiritual framework of recovery has been challenged in recent years by an ever-growing menu of both secular and explicitly religious support groups, all of which differ significantly from AA in their organizational structures, philosophies, meeting rituals, and recovery support tools.

The growing variety of recovery experiences in Canada underscores the need for people concerned about alcohol and other drug problems to become serious students of these divergent recovery strategies. More specifically, it suggests the need for addiction treatment programs and allied helping institutions to forge formal linkages with these new recovery support groups and for professional helpers to become intimately familiar with the operation of such groups. All recovery support groups have individuals who optimally respond, partially respond, and fail to respond to the group's particular approach to recovery initiation and maintenance. Optimal responses could be increased through better matches between individuals and particular support groups. This would require greater professional and public knowledge of recovery support alternatives and encouragement of a philosophy of choice related to recovery pathways. Acquiring such knowledge and adopting such a philosophy has been limited in part by the sparseness of professional and lay literature on alternatives to AA.

We at Trifecta Addiction and Mental Health Services have developed a unique program for

our clients, based on the principles outlined in “Empowering Yourself: The Trifecta Approach to Addiction Recovery.”

The outline of this program is one designed to take the broken individual and help them rebuild themselves, identifying and resolving the underlying issues that ail them. This concept is unique and not offered elsewhere in the field of addictions. The Trifecta Empowerment program addresses these issues clearly and forcefully and in ways that distinguish our approach from traditional 12-step programs. Our program is intended to empower the individual rather than convert.

Not everyone will understand Self Empowerment as a concept of recovery initially, but over the past several years, individuals and families have used Trifecta’s programs as an effective framework to initiate and maintain long-term recovery from life-impairing addictions. These recoveries are cause for celebration, and this program will further ensure an even higher percentage of successful recoveries overall. Those seeking a solution to alcohol and other drug problems—and professionals assisting people with such problems—will find great value in this program.

INTRODUCTION

Most alcoholics and addicts lead two lives. In their public lives, they have jobs, homes, friends, families, or live in anonymity, like anyone else. But in their private, often secret, lives, they are alcoholics and addicts.

If we knew who they were, you might be surprised. Alcoholics and addicts exist at all levels of the economy, the political order, the military, as well as within educational, religious, and cultural establishments. Among the people you know, there may be alcoholics and drug addicts, and you have no idea. The alcoholics and addicts that can be easily identified are only the tip of the iceberg. For every person visibly struggling, there are many others who walk briskly, dress well, pay the mortgage, meet the payroll, and coach the soccer team.

Most alcoholics and addicts keep their second lives secret. Then, inevitably, at some point, the facade of their normality falls away, and they turn into different people. Everything they valued in normal life—job, home, friends, family members—no longer matters. All that

drives them now is the drink or drug. They become as if possessed by demons, falling into self-destructive behaviors.

Managing these two opposite lives takes skill and effort. Early on, there may be a thrill to it—a sense of danger. But over time, it becomes torture. Eventually, depending on circumstances, the balancing act breaks down. The pillars of normality crumble, and the person tumbles down the stairway of losses and abandonments. There is great danger then. Every study of recovery tells us that the chances of survival depend on reaching people while they still have something left to lose. By the time they land in the gutter, only a miracle can save them.

In this program, we want to share with you an approach that will save the person down in the gutter as well as those torn between two lives. It is an approach that makes use of resources and powers that you already have. It will show you the power for good within yourself—not from an external or supernatural higher power. It suggests ways of connecting with other people that you will quickly be able to use.

This approach will not shame or blame you, force a label on you, or require you to declare yourself diseased. It is a wholly positive approach that uses the most effective psychological methods known for bringing about deep emotional and behavioral change. It can work for you regardless of your religious beliefs or lack thereof. You will always be in charge of the changes you make. It will help you recover your life or find a new life of your choosing before your situation becomes unmanageable.

THE TRIFECTA EMPOWERMENT PHILOSOPHY

The "Three S" Philosophy: **Sobriety, Secularity, and Self-Empowerment.**

1. **Sobriety** means that the purpose of participating in our process is to achieve and maintain complete abstinence from alcohol and drugs. If that is also your objective, you will feel you belong.

2. **Secularity** means that you take responsibility for your recovery into your own human hands. Your belief or disbelief in a God or other higher power remains your private business and does not matter in the Empowerment program. As a matter of

statistics, about 40% of people who use Empowerment to recover attend church or another house of worship, which is about the national average.

3. **Self-Empowerment** means that the Empowerment Program is a supportive environment for you to build a life recovery program that fits you and works for you—a Personal Recovery Program (PRP). We do not have, and do not want, a one-size-fits-all program that we suggest you and everyone else adopt.

WHY WE DON'T USE THE 12-STEP APPROACH

- In the first step, AA emphasizes powerlessness. In contrast, the Trifecta Empowerment program focuses on **empowerment**. You are not powerless.
- Step 2 implies one is insane; we believe in your ability to change without such labels. **You are not insane.**
- Step 3 calls for surrender, while Trifecta emphasizes **empowerment and agency**.
- Steps 4, 5, 6, and 7 involve moral inventories and focusing on shortcomings, implying moral deficiencies. The Trifecta Empowerment program helps you **recognize and overcome** challenges without instilling shame or guilt.

SIMILARITIES AND DIFFERENCES WITH 12-STEP

If you are familiar with the recovery universe, you know the dominant force in this sphere for the past fifty years has been the 12-step approach of AA. The first "S" of the Trifecta Empowerment philosophy—Sobriety—is the same as AA's. Like AA, Trifecta supports abstinence, but we differ on other matters. We believe that recovery is possible without adherence to a higher power and that addiction is not caused by moral defects.

Studies have shown that many recoveries happen outside of AA, and we aim to offer an alternative that is empowering, inclusive, and effective for a diverse range of individuals.

Danielle Claughton

Founder/Director, Trifecta Addiction and Mental Health Services

AA Retains Only 5 Percent of Those Who Approach It

The same problem is evident from the other side of the treatment relation: the population of clients or potential clients. Throughout this program, you will hear several individual voices describing their search for a meaningful support group and treatment approach, and how they walked away from their encounters with 12-step groups. Statistically, the walkaways vastly outnumber those who stay.

Over a period of nearly thirty years, AA's own triennial membership surveys reveal the pattern.

Figure 1.1. AA Dropout Rate: Percentage of First-Time Attendees Still Attending After Indicated Months

Don McIntire, an advocate of AA, analyzed AA's membership survey numbers in the Alcoholism Treatment Quarterly and found that out of a hundred newcomers who attend their first AA meeting, only five are left at the end of a year.

McIntire cites the following:

- More than 80% of first-time attendees walk away within the first month.
- At the three-month mark, 90% have walked out; only 10% remain.
- By the end of the year, half of that 10% are gone. Only 5% are left.

Part One: A PERSON ADDICTED IS A PERSON IN CONFLICT

Every person carries his or her own doctor inside.

One thing all active addicts wonder about, even before they have any desire to stop, is the great mystery of recovery. Every day, wherever people use addictive substances, a certain number of them decide to turn their lives around and stop.

At first, you may see these people enraged, stupefied, intoxicated, passed out, or otherwise in the grip of their addiction. They're isolated, alone, or at war with those around them.

Later, you see them as lively, intelligent, warm, sympathetic human beings leading sober, fulfilling lives. They laugh heartily at themselves and others in a recovery group or social

setting, sober and genuinely enjoying life.

You might ask yourself:

- What happened to bring about this transformation?
- How is it possible that these are the same people?
- Where did these bright, warm, lively, sober folks come from?
- Where had they been hiding during their active addiction?
- How can we make this transformation happen more often?

That's the great mystery of recovery from chemical dependency.

Trifecta Addiction and Mental Health Services is here to answer these questions and guide you through this transformative journey.

The Divided Self

The person in the grip of dependency on an addictive substance is a person in conflict, with a personality split into two opposing parts.

There is the original person—the one that existed before addictive substances took over as a priority. Then there is the addict, who lives in the person's mind and body like a parasite, draining resources and driving the individual toward premature death.

The inner struggle between these two personalities inhabiting the same person is the central psychological reality of life as an addict. The metaphor of “Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde” remains a favored comparison for this condition. In Robert Louis Stevenson’s The Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde, Hyde was the addict who committed unspeakable acts while under the influence, while Dr. Jekyll was the rational physician, a pillar of the community. The thrilling realization of the story is that they are, in fact, one and the same person.

This internal conflict within addicted individuals is characteristic of addiction, and many leading authorities recognize it as such. This internal conflict, although often uncomfortable and painful to the point of torture, carries great hope and can be the basis for positive change.

The Divided Self Is a Clinical Reality

The addict’s divided self is more than just a literary metaphor—it is a clinical reality. Numerous writers with extensive clinical experience and a nonjudgmental perspective have observed and described this conflict as a defining experience of addiction.

Addiction professionals and Trifecta Addiction and Mental Health Services observe the following profound generalization:

Addicts simultaneously want—more than anything—both to maintain an uninterrupted relationship with their drug of choice and to break free of the drug. Behaviorally, this paradox is evidenced in both the incredible lengths to which an addict will go to sustain a relationship with the drug, and in their repeated efforts to exert control over it and sever their relationship with it.

We can express this insight in fewer words:

The fierce power of an addict's obsession with drugs is matched, when the timing is right, by an equally vigorous drive to be free of them.

Substance dependence is defined as "a persistent desire or unsuccessful effort to cut down or control substance use," or "knowledge of having a persistent or recurrent physical or psychological problem likely caused or exacerbated by the substance." In other words, a dependent person can be recognized not only by their use of substances, but also by their recognition that the substances are causing problems, and by their desire to cut down or control personal use. This is the essence of the inner conflict.

"A" (Addicted Self) Versus "S" (Sober Self)

If you are trying to clarify the inner landscape of a substance-using person, you might encounter confusion. Experts disagree about basic definitions—addiction or dependence, different forms of alcoholism, and whether tolerance and withdrawal are essential to defining addiction.

To simplify this, we propose a radical simplification.

Everything that speaks for, promotes, or defends the use of addictive substances, we will call "A" for Addicted Self. Everything that speaks for, promotes, or defends living life free of addictive substances, we will call "S" for Sober Self.

If you hear an inner voice suggesting a drink, that comes from your "A." The voice that suggests a bike ride, likely comes from your "S" (unless your drug connection is on your bike route).

The point of this metaphor is to create a functional basis for understanding and working productively with the inner conflict that arises from addictive substances.

In the Trifecta Empowerment approach, we acknowledge the conflict between “A” and “S,” recognizing that hope lies within this conflict. Without the pain of conflict, there is no drive for change.

In Conflict Lies Hope

Inner conflict is not enjoyable. The ambivalence is akin to standing on the fulcrum of a teeter-totter, constantly fighting for balance. Some people may use substances more as an escape from this stress. But without the discomfort, there is no change.

Imagine an individual whose experience is entirely rational and sober, with no negative impact from substance use—they would have no reason to change. On the other hand, someone completely consumed by addiction without any desire for something better is also unlikely to change. It is the presence of both “A” and “S” that makes transformation possible.

The First Step to Empowerment

“We admit we were powerless over drugs and alcohol, that our lives became unmanageable.”

Enough!

If you can say that and mean it, you are ready to take the first step.

Do you feel that your life is out of control? Do you struggle with dependence on alcohol or other substances? Have you tried to quit and failed? Are you tired of trying? If so, then admitting that some area of your life is unmanageable is an essential step toward empowerment.

For most of us, the first step means stopping the self-deception. Stop making excuses, blaming others, or pretending there isn't a problem.

The first step is simple: acknowledge your problem. Lay it on the table and look at it honestly.

H.O.W. - Honesty, Openness, Willingness

Honesty. You cannot put your life in order until you are willing to be honest about it. We often mask our reality with delusions and denial. Honesty is the starting point for true empowerment.

Openness. You will encounter new ideas on your journey. It may feel uncomfortable or scary, but openness to the Empowerment process is vital. Without it, change cannot occur.

Willingness. Making an effort means being willing to think new thoughts, try, and act. Willingness is crucial—old habits may fight to stay alive, but effort will bring you closer to freedom.

For your sake, give this program an honest, open, and patient try for ninety days. If you find it wasn't worth it, you are free to choose another path.

My First Step: Knowing My Problem

To begin with the Trifecta Empowerment program, you must answer three basic questions:

1. What is the problem?

2. What is the solution?

3. What can I do to use that solution and become empowered?

The first step is to recognize what the problem is. For those struggling with addiction, the problem is powerlessness over substances, resulting in an unmanageable life.

The Trifecta Empowerment approach emphasizes hope, strength, and the power that lies within you. By nurturing your "Sober Self" and weakening the influence of your "Addicted Self," you can reclaim control and achieve lasting recovery.Exercise 1: BEING OUT OF CONTROL - HOW DID IT FEEL?

Think of a time when your life felt out of control. Perhaps your car hit an icy spot on the road, or a sudden thunderstorm ruined an important event. Maybe you were called for jury duty when you had other plans, or an illness made it impossible for you to carry on with your life as usual. Whatever the situation, think about it deeply, then write or draw what happened in the space below. Ensure that your words or drawing convey how you felt when things were out of control.

Key Principles for Recovery from Alcoholism and Drug Addiction

Experience has shown that recovery from alcoholism and drug addiction is contingent upon the following principles, and more:

1. Having a sincere desire to stop.
2. Not only admitting, but accepting powerlessness over drugs and alcohol.
3. Viewing addiction as a fatal, incurable illness of the body, mind, and soul.
4. Committing ourselves to the program to continue recovering by empowering ourselves.
5. Understanding that our drug of choice is a poison.
6. Making it our business to understand how these drugs affect us.
7. Realizing that we are no longer alcoholics or addicts once we stop.
8. Learning, practicing, and having faith in our ability to empower ourselves in recovery.
9. Believing in ourselves, and having the conviction that we can never return to substance use.
10. Gaining knowledge of how these substances affect our health.

11. Using this knowledge to guard against relapse and to continue empowering ourselves.

12. Maintaining a mental picture of our personal empowerment and the power we have in our recovery.

What can you add?

1. ……

2. ……

3. ……

The 1st STEP to Empowerment

Step 1: We admit we were powerless over our addiction and that our lives had become unmanageable.

THE GOAL: To gather evidence that our drug of choice has become unrealistically important in our lives, that we are truly powerless over it, and that the consequences of our addiction have made our lives unmanageable.

CAUTION: Answering questions about our actions in the past may bring up painful feelings and cause us to feel that we are bad people. This is not the intention; our intention is to

discover the link between our chemical use and our abnormal behavior. It is our behavior in addiction we are evaluating, not our character.

Step One is the “problem step”—the only one in which the problem, our addiction, is explicitly mentioned.

Let’s Talk About “DENIAL”

Denial is the ability to believe that our addictions are not hurting us, even when it is obvious that they are.

Write about your denial…

……
……..

FIRST STEP WORK PAPER

The first step towards Empowerment is the foundation of recovery. The following worksheets are designed to help you recognize and accept, on a deep level, the powerlessness and unmanageability of your past, and how to move past it to empower yourself towards sobriety.

POWERLESSNESS

1. How did substances put your life, or the lives of others, in jeopardy?

a. ……..

b. ……..

c. ……..

2. How did you lose self-respect due to your substance use?

a. ……..

b. ……..

c. ……..

3. What past behaviors did your spouse, family, friends, or employer object to most?

a. ……..

b. ……..

c. ……..

4. How did you try to control your consumption of substances or alcohol?

a. ……..

b. ……..

c. ……..

5. Give four examples of how powerlessness (loss of control) revealed itself in your past experiences:

a. ……..

b. ……..

c. ……..

d. ……..

6. What types of physical abuse happened to you or others as a result of your past substance use?

a. ……..

b. ……..

c. ……..

7. What is your current physical condition (e.g., heart, liver, etc.)?

……..

8. What is the difference between admittance and acceptance?

……..

Are you admitting or accepting?

……..

Define how you are admitting or accepting through your behavior:

……..

9. What convinces you that you can no longer use alcohol or drugs safely? (How can self-empowerment help you in this case?)

……..

10. Were you an alcoholic, chemically dependent, or both?

……..

This part of the Trifecta Empowerment program is about recognizing and acknowledging the powerlessness that substances have created in your life, and using this realization as the foundation for empowerment and growth. Recognizing denial, admitting powerlessness, and distinguishing between admitting and accepting are crucial steps toward embracing self-empowerment and moving forward in your journey towards sobriety.

About Your Life, Drinking, and Drug History

Each client is expected to complete a written history during their first week of treatment. This history should include significant events and consequences related to your life,

drinking, and drug use. Be as detailed and honest as possible.

Areas to be included and addressed are:

1. Family of Origin - Parents, siblings, and other significant relationships.
2. Life, Drinking, and Drug Use - Work history, education, and social environment.
3. Present Status - Current relationship status (married, separated, etc.), employment (working, unemployed, etc.).

Please write a paragraph about how you feel about using empowerment to recover from your addictions

Life, Drinking, and Drug History

Write a detailed life, drinking, and drug history, beginning as far back as you can remember. Use the following questions as a guide. Remember to be as honest and thorough as possible.

1. Where and when were you born? Briefly describe what your parents were like.
2. What was life like at home? What was school like for you?
3. Describe your friends.
4. What were some of the rules and values that were important in your home?

5. What circumstances created stress in your home (financial, legal, marital issues, frequent moving, drinking, or drug use by others in your family)?

6. How did you feel about yourself as a person? (Did you see yourself as outgoing or shy, confident or confused, good or bad, smart or struggling?)

7. When did your use of alcohol and/or drugs begin? What was it like?

8. When did your use turn into addictive use?

9. What are some pleasant memories from your using?

10. Are there any painful memories? Describe them.

11. Have you experienced any feelings of guilt or remorse as a result of your use?

12. Any feelings of resentment?

13. How have your values changed over the years? Did you ever violate your own values and feel remorse?

14. Have there been any major losses as a result of your using? Describe them.

15. What are your interests and hobbies? How have they changed over time?

16. Describe your social life.

17. Has your use resulted in physical violence to yourself or others?

18. What has your use done to your self-respect and the respect of others?

19. Has your alcohol or drug use caused damage to or resulted in the loss of any relationships?

20. Have you tried to control your use of alcohol or drugs? In what ways?

21. Are you convinced that you cannot safely use alcohol or drugs?

After completing this assignment:

- Do you have any further doubts about being chemically dependent?

- Can you admit that you are dependent?

- What is the difference between admitting and accepting? You may have already admitted your dependency, but now it's time to accept it and commit to empowering yourself. You are stronger than you think, and you will walk upright on this new journey.

This assignment is to be completed and handed in to your counsellor by Day 7 of your treatment program

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UNMANAGEABILITY

1. What does unmanageability mean to you?
2. What could you identify as your past "social unmanageability"?

a.

b.

c.

3. Give 4 examples of your past sober personal unmanageability:

a.

b.

c.

d.

4. What goals have you set for your life? (How will new empowerment propel you?)

a.

b.

c.

5. Prior to treatment, how did you try to achieve these goals?

6. Give examples of feelings you have tried to alter with the use of chemicals:

a.

b.

c.

7. How have you tried to change your image prior to treatment?

8. What crisis besides the one that got you into treatment now would have eventually happened?

9. What do you think is different about you from other people?

10. Give 15 reasons why you should continue with the program you are now in and how you feel self-empowerment (Trifecta) will affect your new life:

11.

12.

13.

14.

15.

16.

17.

18.

19.

20.

21.

22.

23.

24.

Words of Wisdom

“I don’t know who, or what, put the question, I don’t know when it was put. I don’t even remember answering. But at some moment I did answer Yes to Someone, or Something, and from that hour I was certain that existence is meaningful and that, therefore, my life, in self-surrender, had a goal.”

—Dag Hammarskjold

ACCEPTANCE

What is Acceptance?

One way to understand the principle of acceptance is to meditate upon it in the context of AA’s much-used prayer:

“God grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, courage to change the things I can, and the wisdom to know the difference.”

Essentially, this is asking for the resources of grace by which we may make spiritual progress under all conditions.

Greatly emphasized in this prayer is the need for the kind of wisdom that discriminates between what is possible and what is not. Life’s difficulties will require many degrees of acceptance as we apply this principle. Sometimes we need to accept conditions for each day, for tomorrow, or for conditions that may never change. Similarly, we must also learn to accept faults in ourselves and others as part of our recovery journey, which becomes possible through acceptance and empowerment.

On entering the Trifecta program, we experience a new way of staying clean and sober. Our journey is founded on the understanding that we can rise above substances and become whole again. In the first steps of Trifecta's Empowerment Recovery Program, we admitted that we were once powerless over drugs and alcohol, and that our lives had become unmanageable. We came to believe that this new empowerment will restore us to sanity. Accepting our need for change and embracing empowerment becomes our foundation for sobriety and growth.

Through empowerment, we no longer rely solely on willpower; instead, we embrace willingness to live with acceptance. And when we do, freedom follows. There is no irretrievable disaster.

This kind of acceptance and faith can produce 100% sobriety. Carrying these attitudes into our emotional problems helps us grow, even if we can't become completely free from fear, anger, and pride.

The exercise of practicing acceptance each day and returning to a foundation of humility allows us to grow emotionally and spiritually. When we are grateful for our blessings and embrace joyful gratitude, we displace feelings of conceit and begin to love outwardly, which brings deeper peace.

Honesty in Recovery

Honesty is very important in addiction recovery because dishonesty, with others and with oneself, perpetuates the disease. Honesty, both with oneself and others, is a cornerstone of recovery.

In recovery, being rigorously honest means making a conscious effort to be truthful with yourself and others in all areas of your life. This doesn't mean brutal honesty that harms others, but rather a form of honesty that promotes growth and accountability.

Honesty is crucial in addiction recovery due to the power of dishonesty with others and self-delusion. These are major mechanisms that perpetuate the disease. The major weapon for fighting delusion is honesty.

Need in Addiction

Especially in addiction, dishonesty fuels delusion and promotes dysfunctional behavior and relationships. Honesty, both with oneself and others, is a cornerstone of recovery.

Like most things, honesty may appear to be black and white, but it isn't. We can place ourselves on a scale from pathological liar to brutally honest, depending on different situations in our lives—whether personal or professional.

- **Pathological lying**: This is a level of dishonesty that is truly extreme. Pathological liars weave fantastic stories about who they are and what they have done, often symptomatic of a deeper character disorder or even psychosis.
- **Fraud and theft**: At the extreme end, fraud and theft may indicate deeper character disorders but are also related to addictive behaviors. Many addicts find themselves involved in these activities, largely due to their addiction.
- Minor cheating: A more common form of dishonesty, which can include:
- Adultery or infidelity
- "Borrowing" that never gets returned
- Copying books, tapes, or software without paying
- Lying on income tax returns
- Stealing supplies from an employer
- **Cash register honesty**: At this level, a person wouldn't "take money from the register." They have an understanding of what is clearly dishonest, such as theft or cheating, and avoid such actions.
- **Guarded truth**: This is where what you say is technically true, but you may not correct others' misinterpretations. Dishonesty by omission occurs rather than by commission. Politicians are notorious for this level of honesty.
- **Essentially honest**: At this stage, honesty is the norm, although exceptions are made for certain situations. "Little white lies" may not seem like a big deal, especially if they're not for personal gain or don't harm anyone. It's difficult for someone engaged in addictive behavior to maintain this level of honesty.
- **Rigorously honest**: This doesn't mean perfect honesty, but a striving toward it. Like rigorous exercise that makes you sweat, rigorous honesty means making a conscientious

effort to be honest in all your affairs.

- **Brutally honest**: An addict can overdo honesty. Telling someone, “You sure are ugly,” may be honest but insensitive to the other person’s feelings. Brutal honesty can sometimes mask ulterior motives.

With any level of honesty, a person needs to make a value judgment between brutal and rigorous honesty. The Trifecta program suggests “progress, not perfection.”

Dealing with Consequences

People often face consequences for dishonesty, even if they aren’t “caught.” When you lie, you immediately increase the amount of information you need to remember. You have to remember the truth and the lie—and sometimes multiple lies told to different people. This leads to spending more energy on keeping the lie going than it would have taken to just tell the truth. Honesty makes relationships, and recovery, easier.

Taking Risks

Sometimes, telling the truth does lead to trouble. However, the trouble is often not as bad as imagined, and the freedom that comes with honesty far outweighs the risk. Honesty often garners support from others and provides a sense of integrity.

This is an Exercise in Honesty

In recovery, it’s essential to tell the truth. As stated in AA meetings, this is a program of rigorous honesty. “Those who do not recover are people who cannot or will not completely give themselves to this simple program, usually men and women who are constitutionally incapable of being honest with themselves.”

Why is honesty so important? Because dishonesty leads to fear, and fear leads to drug and alcohol use. “Rigorous honesty is the most important tool in learning to live for today.” You can’t solve problems if you lie. Sobriety requires a commitment to reality—accepting the truth of your situation.

People who are chemically dependent often believe that telling the truth will lead to rejection. In reality, the opposite is true. People can only accept you if they know the real you. If you keep secrets, you’ll never feel fully known or loved. An old AA saying states, “We are only as sick as our secrets.” Keeping secrets keeps you isolated from others.

You cannot be a practicing alcoholic or drug addict without lying to yourself. The illness requires you to lie and believe those lies in order to continue. Lies protect you from facing the truth about your condition. If you had known the truth, you’d have realized you needed treatment, which may have been too frightening to face. So, you kept the truth hidden.

Honesty Exercise

This exercise will help you confront how you distorted reality and guide you toward practicing honesty. Answer each question as completely as possible.

1. Denial: Telling yourself or others, “I don’t have a problem.” Write down examples of when you used this technique to avoid the truth.

2. Minimizing: Making the problem smaller than it was. You might have told someone you had “a couple of beers” when you actually had six. Write down examples of when you distorted reality by minimizing the problem.

3. Hostility: Becoming angry or making threats when someone confronted you about your substance use. Give examples of this behavior.

4. Rationalization: Making excuses, such as, “I had a hard day,” or, “Things are bad.” Give examples of when you justified your use of chemicals.

5. Blaming: Shifting responsibility to someone else, e.g., “The police were out to get me,” or, “My spouse is overreacting.” Provide examples of when you blamed others for problems you caused.

6. Intellectualizing: Overthinking the problem instead of taking action, e.g., “Everyone I know drinks,” or, “I read that drinking is part of our culture.” Provide examples of how you used intellectual reasoning to justify your substance use.

7. Diversion: Bringing up another topic of conversation to avoid the issue at hand. Provide examples of when you did this.

Lying Exercise

8. List five lies you told to someone close to you about your drinking or drug use.

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

9. List five lies you told yourself about your drug problem.

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

10. List 10 people you have lied to.

11.

12.

13.

14.

15.

16.

17.

18.

19.

20.

Reflection

11. How do you feel about your lying? Describe how you feel about yourself when you lie.

12. What do you think will change in your life if you begin to tell the truth?

13. How do you use lies in other areas of your life?

14. When are you most likely to lie? Is it when you've been drinking or using drugs?

15. Why do you lie? List 5 reasons:

16.

17.

18.

19.

20.

Common Lies in Chemical Dependency

16. Give a personal example of each type of lie:

- Breaking promises
- Pretending to be sober when you are intoxicated
- Blackouts: Pretending you remember when you don’t
- Minimizing your use
- Telling yourself you were in control when you weren’t
- Telling others you rarely get high
- Hiding morning drinking
- Hiding your supply

- Substituting alcohol for food

- Saying you were sick when you were actually hungover

In the long run, lying leaves you feeling isolated and alone. Recovery demands living in the truth. Statements like “I am an alcoholic,” “My life is unmanageable,” and “I need help” are honest admissions from those living in reality.

2nd Step of Empowerment - OURSELVES

Before beginning the 2nd Step of Empowerment, we came to realize that new resources were accessible to us in times of need. Once we realized we could empower ourselves to rise above our reliance on drugs and alcohol, we gained the ability, knowledge, and strength necessary to take a step forward without fear. We became self-assured and empowered in our innovative, healthy decision-making skills, and embraced a newfound sense of hope.

We refuse to embark upon this next step with fear, reluctance, or dishonesty. By now, we have given ourselves the assurance in our new Empowerment. Now it is time to apply faith and trust that this Empowerment will propel us confidently toward our goals. We know that only good can result from making a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves. With the shield of valor, stepping forth in confidence, we begin this journey, which will ultimately lead to a successful, fulfilling, and happy life.

The dictionary defines “moral” as being “concerned with the judgment of goodness or badness of character and behaviors.” It also describes moral as “conforming to established standards of good behavior,” and “arising from conscience.” In our journey, we understand that morals are habits of demeanor. A moral person is virtuous, upright, and maintains standards that reflect love, righteousness, and integrity. Becoming a moral human being, someone of true integrity, is our utmost objective in recovery. Integrity, meaning sincerity, truthfulness, and honor, becomes our model. To reach this, we must conduct a personal moral inventory to identify deficiencies in our character and to become more acquainted with ourselves. This awareness will enable us to mold our lives and positively progress in our recovery.

Before beginning this step, it is important to be prepared, willing, and capable of being completely honest, thorough, and courageous in writing our moral inventory. Through the faith that Empowerment has given us, we will find the courage necessary to carry out this step. Applying the principles we've learned in recovery so far will help us complete this step, leading to significant positive life changes.

Honesty is the essential element of this step. When we are honest with ourselves about our flaws, weaknesses, and negative traits, we gain the capacity for positive change. With honesty about our powerlessness, our addictive behaviors, and our addiction, we open the door to transformation. Opportunities for growth, development, and positive alteration await as we work through this step. In doing so, we utilize the tools that Trifecta has given us, including acceptance, hope, commitment, faith, courage, willingness, love, open-mindedness, and most importantly, honesty, which is the foundation of all these principles.

Before starting this step, remember that change begins in the mind, moves to the soul, and manifests in our decisions. We are the architects of our own destiny, and by living one day at a time, we gain the strength and confidence to face life on its own terms. As we work on our moral inventory, we write down the negative characteristics that were connected to our addiction and ourselves. This inventory will expose our character defects, such as arrogance, self-pity, greed, dishonesty, egotism, and more, as well as the positive traits we want to build upon, such as love, faith, sincerity, kindness, and perseverance.

Empowerment provides us with the tools to effectively work through this step. While the journey may be emotionally challenging, in the end, good will prevail. As we honestly look inward, we will gain the awareness, knowledge, and understanding necessary for recovery. We will realize how addiction distorted our perspective and thrived on anger and resentment. As we write down our moral inventory, a sense of peace and calm will fill us, knowing that we are moving toward the freedom we desire.

This step teaches us that our character defects are the result of losing touch with our Empowerment. Now that we are clean and clear-headed, we want to break free from the forces that were destroying us. We desire positive change, spiritual growth, and personal freedom, and we take the necessary steps to remove these defects. While awareness begins with this step, future steps in the Trifecta program will equip us with the strength and ability to remove these flaws and lead to a total character transformation.

True change occurs when we are prepared and ready to handle it. Therefore, we must gain all the awareness possible during this step and start preparing for positive change to commence. Progress, not perfection, is the key to lasting recovery, and as we work this step honestly, positive behavioral change will follow. Self-examination opens the door to transformation.

In recovery, balance is essential. As we work through our personal inventory, it is important to examine all areas of our lives with honesty and courage to achieve the best possible results. By maintaining equilibrium, we can achieve victory over our defects and ensure that we remain steady and unwavering in our journey toward positive change.

MADE A SEARCHING AND FEARLESS MORAL INVENTORY OF OURSELVES

One of the requirements for sobriety is the confession of personality defects through a moral inventory. This step may seem intimidating, but these worksheets are designed to make the process simple and clear. Before starting, ensure that you have completed the previous step and check with your therapist or counselor to confirm that you are ready.

Some people struggle with this step because of the painful memories it may bring up. However, the pain doesn't come from writing the inventory; it comes from resisting the process. The freedom we seek comes from releasing fears and secrets that have held us back.

Here are some tips to help you with your moral inventory:

- Try listing resentments in categories (e.g., family, school, relationships, work).
- Write consistently, even if only for a few minutes each day.
- Don't rush through it; be honest, and remember that you are the one who benefits from this exercise.

Glossary of Terms:

- Moral Inventory: A list of personality defects, violations of moral principles, character flaws, and dysfunctional behaviors.
- Frightened: A temporary or constant state of fear.
- Inconsiderate: Acting without thought or consideration for others.
- Character: Moral strength or integrity, often acquired through self-discipline.
- Self-Centered: Concerned only with one's own affairs; selfish.
- Defect: A flaw or shortcoming, a lack of something necessary for completeness.
- Self-Seeker: A person who seeks only or mainly to further their own interests.

RESENTMENT INVENTORY PROMPT SHEET

Here is a list of people, institutions, and principles that may be helpful in your resentment inventory. Feel free to add to the lists if you need to.

PEOPLE

- Father (Step)
- Mother (Step)
- Sisters (Step)
- Brothers (Step)
- Aunts
- Uncles

- Cousins
- Clergy
- Police
- Lawyers
- Judges
- Doctors
- Employers
- Employees
- Co-workers
- In-laws
- Husbands
- Wives
- Creditors
- Childhood Friends
- School Friends
- Teachers
- Lifelong Friends
- Best Friends
- Acquaintances
- Girlfriends
- Boyfriends
- Parole Officers
- Probation Officers
- A.A. Friends
- C.A. Friends

- N.A. Friends

INSTITUTIONS

- Marriage
- Bible
- Church
- Religion
- Races
- Law
- Authority
- Government
- Education System
- Correctional System
- Mental Health System
- Philosophy
- Nationality

PRINCIPLES

- God/Deity
- Retribution
- Ten Commandments
- Jesus Christ
- Satan

- Death
- Life After Death
- Heaven
- Hell
- Sin
- Adultery
- Golden Rule
- Original Sin
- Seven Deadly Sins

FEAR INVENTORY PROMPT SHEET

Here is a list of fears that may be helpful in your fear inventory. Feel free to add to the lists if you need to.

- Fear of God
- Fear of Dying
- Fear of Insanity
- Fear of Insecurity
- Fear of Rejection
- Fear of Loneliness
- Fear of Diseases
- Fear of Alcohol
- Fear of Drugs
- Fear of Relapse
- Fear of Sex

- Fear of Sin
- Fear of Self-Expression
- Fear of Authority
- Fear of Heights
- Fear of Unemployment
- Fear of Employment
- Fear of Parents
- Fear of Losing a Wife
- Fear of Losing a Husband
- Fear of Losing a Child
- Fear of Animals
- Fear of Insects
- Fear of Police
- Fear of Jail
- Fear of Doctors
- Fear of Stealing
- Fear of Creditors
- Fear of Drowning
- Fear of Men
- Fear of Women
- Fear of Being Alone
- Fear of People
- Fear of Crying
- Fear of Poverty
- Fear of Races

- Fear of the Unknown
- Fear of Abandonment
- Fear of Intimacy
- Fear of Disapproval
- Fear of Physical Pain
- Fear of Fear
- Fear of Being Found Out
- Fear of Homosexuals & Lesbians
- Fear of Failure
- Fear of Success
- Fear of Responsibility

EMPOWERMENT STEP INVENTORY

Resentments, Fears & Sexual Conduct/Harm Done to Others

Use the following tables for all of the following:

Resentments

- Column 1: Resentments

List all people, places, things, institutions, ideas, or principles with whom you are angry, resentful, feel hurt, or threatened by.

- Column 2: The Cause

What happened? Be specific about why you were angry.

- Column 3: Affects My...

How did it make you feel? Specifically, how did it affect the seven parts of self?

- Column 4: Where Was I to Blame

What's the truth here? Where was your responsibility in this relationship? What might you have done instead? Where were you at fault?

Fears

List your fears. Then write about why you have each fear. Has self-reliance failed you?

Sexual Conduct/Harm Done to Others

Request some clarity from your therapist regarding these things.

Again, make a list for yourself. What happened in each instance? How did it make you feel?

The Seven Parts of Self Defined

- Self-Esteem: How I think of myself.
- Pride: How I think others view me.
- Pocketbook: Basic desire for money, property, possessions, etc.
- Personal Relations: Our relations with other people.
- Ambition: Our goals, plans, and designs for the future.
- Emotional Security: General sense of personal well-being.
- Sex Relations: Basic drive for sexual intimacy.

Helpful Hints

Preparation: Before you start this written step, please ask your primary therapist regarding any questions you may have.

Note:

1. This inventory is not an exercise in beating yourself up. Be scrupulously honest but fair to yourself. Inventory your strengths as well as your defects.
2. The following checklist merely suggests what some people consider flaws. You must decide how they fit with your own moral code. Do not be limited by this list—add your own.

It is in this step that you begin to discover your values—what you consider right and wrong, functional and dysfunctional behavior—and how you live up to your standards.

3. This inventory is about who you are now, not who you were when you were drinking and taking drugs. Be careful, however, not to blame all past bad behavior on drinking and drugs if the seed of that bad behavior still exists in you.
4. Don’t be discouraged when your character defects are not immediately lifted after you have completed your next step.

Into Action: On the following list, check all of your defects and all of your assets.

This is an inventory of both bad and good characteristics. Then discuss your defects (with your best example of each) on the Review of Flaws form.

Glossary of Words Used in Moral Inventory

- Moral Inventory: A list of personality defects, violations of moral principles, defects in character, maladjustments, and dysfunctional behavior.

- Frightened: A temporary or continual state of fear; anxious.
- Inconsiderate: Without thought or consideration of others.
- Nature: The essential characteristic of a thing.
- Character: Moral vigor or firmness, especially as acquired through self-discipline.
- Self-Centered: Occupying or concerned only with one's own affairs; same as selfish.
- Defect: Lack of something necessary for completeness; flaw; weakness; fault; same as shortcoming.
- Self-Seeker: A person who seeks only or mainly to further their own interests.
- Selfish: Too much concerned with one's own welfare or interests and having little or no concern for others (same as self-centered).
- Shortcoming: Falling short of what is expected or required (same as defect).
- Wrong: Immoral, improper; not suitable or appropriate.

Checklist of Flaws and Assets

Character Defect	Opposite Asset	Character Defect	Opposite Asset
Aggressive, belligerent	Good-natured, gentle	Lazy, indolent	Industrious, conscientious
Angry	Forgiving, calm, generous	Loud	Tasteful, quiet
Apathetic	Interested, concerned, alert	Lustful	Healthy sexuality
Apprehensive, afraid	Calm, courageous	Lying	Honest
Argumentative, quarrelsome	Agreeable	Manipulative	Candid, honest, non-controlling
Arrogant, insolent	Unassuming, humble	Masked, closed	Honest, open, candid
Attacking, critical	Fair, self-restrained	Nagging	Supportive
Avoidant	Faces problems and acts	Narrow-minded	Open-minded
Blocking	Honest, intuitive	Obscene, crude	Modest, courteous
Boastful	Modest, humble	Over-emotional	Emotionally stable

Character Traits Workbook

Character Defects and Opposite Assets

- Frightened:

A temporary or continual state of fear; anxious.

- Inconsiderate:

Without thought or consideration of others.

- Nature:

The essential characteristic of a thing.

- Character:

Moral vigor or firmness, especially as acquired through self-discipline.

- Self-Centered:

Occupying or concerned only with one's own affairs; same as selfish.

- Defect:

Lack of something necessary for completeness; flaw; weakness; fault; same as shortcoming.

- Self-Seeker:

A person who seeks only or mainly to further their own interests.

- Selfish:

Too much concerned with one's own welfare or interests and having little or no concern for others (same as self-centered).

- Shortcoming:

Falling short of what is expected or required (same as defect).

- Wrong:

Immoral, improper; not suitable or appropriate.

Checklist of Flaws and Assets

Character Defect (Negative Trait)	Opposite Asset (Positive Trait)
Frightened	Courageous
Inconsiderate	Thoughtful
Self-Centered	Caring of others
Defect	Completeness
Self-Seeker	Selfless
Selfish	Altruistic
Shortcoming	Strength
Wrong	Moral
Aggressive	Gentle
Angry	Forgiving
Apathetic	Interested
Apprehensive	Calm
Argumentative	Agreeable
Arrogant	Humble
Attacking	Fair
Avoidant	Faces problems
Blocking	Honest
Boastful	Modest
Careless	Careful
Cheating	Honest
Competitive	Cooperative
Compulsive	Free
Conceited	Humble
Contradictory	Reasonable

Controlling	Lets go
Cowardly	Brave
Critical	Non-judgmental
Cynical	Open-minded
Deceitful	Honest
Defensive	Open to criticism
Defiant	Respectful
Denying	Accepting
Dependent	Self-reliant
Depressed	Cheerful
Dirty	Clean
Dishonest	Honest
Disloyal	Loyal
Disobedient	Obedient
Disrespectful	Respectful
Enabling	Setting boundaries
Envying	Empathetic
Evasive	Straightforward
Exaggerating	Realistic
Faithless	Reliable
Falsely modest	Honest
Falsely prideful	Humble
Fantasizing	Practical
Fearful	Confident
Forgetful	Responsible
Gluttonous	Moderate
Gossiping	Kind

Greedy	Generous
Hateful	Loving
Hypersensitive	Tolerant
Ill-tempered	Good-tempered
Impatient	Patient
Impulsive	Consistent
Inconsiderate	Thoughtful
Indecisive	Decisive
Indifferent	Caring
Inflexible	Open-minded
Insecure	Self-confident
Insincere	Honest
Intolerant	Understanding
Untrustworthy	Trustworthy
Useless	Helpful
Vain	Modest
Vindictive	Forgiving
Violent	Gentle
Vulgar	Polite
Wasteful	Thrifty
Willful	Accepting of the inevitable

Careless Careful, painstaking, concerned Perfectionistic Realistic goals

Cheating Honest (socially) Pessimistic Realistic, hopeful, optimistic

Competitive Cooperative Possessive Generous

Compulsive Free Prejudiced Open-minded

Conceited, self-important Humble, modest Procrastinates Disciplined, acts promptly

Contradictory, oppositional, contrary, pigheaded Reasonable, agreeable Projecting (negative) Clear-sighted, optimistic

Controlling Lets go, especially of others' lives Rationalizing Candid, honest

Cowardly Brave Resentful, bitter, hateful Forgiving

Critical Non-judgmental, praising, tolerant Resisting Growing, willing to grow

Cynical Open-minded Rude, discourteous Polite, courteous

Deceitful Guileless, honest Sarcastic Praising, tolerant

Defensive Open to criticism Self-important Humble, modest

Defiant, contemptuous Respectful Self-centered Caring of others

Denying Honest, accepting Self-destructive, self-defeating Self-fulfilling

Dependent Accepts help but is self-reliant Self-hating Self-accepting, loving

Depressed, morose Hopeful, optimistic, cheerful Self-justifying Admitting wrongs, humble

Dirty, poor hygiene Clean Self-pitying Grateful, realistic, accepting

Dishonest Honest Self-righteous Humble, understanding

Disloyal, treacherous Faithful, loyal Self-seeking Selfless, concerned for others

Disobedient Obedient Selfish Altruistic, concerned with others

Disrespectful, insolent Respectful, reverent Shy Outgoing

Enabling Setting boundaries, tough love Slothful (lazy) Industrious, taking action

Envying Empathetic, generous, admiring Spiteful, malicious Forgiving

Evasive, deceitful Candid, straightforward Stealing Honest

Exaggerating Honest, realistic Stubborn Open-minded, willing

Faithless, disloyal Reliable, faithful Sullen Cheerful

Falsely modest Honest, has self-esteem Superior, grandiose, pretentious Humble

Falsely prideful Modest, humble Superstitious Realistic, no magical thinking

Fantasizing, unrealistic Practical, realistic Suspicious Trusting

Fearful Confident, courageous Tense Calm, serene

Forgetful Responsible Thinking negatively Being positive

Gluttonous, excessive Moderate Treacherous Trustworthy

Gossiping Closed-mouth, kind, praising Undisciplined, self-indulgent Disciplined

Greedy Moderate, generous, sharing Unfair Fair

Hateful Forgiving, loving, concerned for others Unfriendly, hostile, harsh Friendly

Hypersensitive Tolerant, doesn't personalize Ungrateful Thankful, grateful

Ill-tempered, irritable Good-tempered, calm Unkind, mean, malicious, spiteful Kind

Impatient Patient Unsupportive of others Supportive

Impulsive, reckless Consistent, considered actions Untrustworthy, unreliable, dishonest Trustworthy

Inconsiderate Thoughtful, considerate Useless, destructive Helpful

Indecisive, timid Firm, decisive Vain Modest, humble

Indifferent, apathetic, aloof Caring Vindictive Forgiving

Inflexible, stubborn Open-minded, flexible Violent Gentle

Insecure, anxious Self-confident, secure Vulgar Polite

Insincere, hypocritical Sincere, honest Wasteful Thrifty

Intolerant Tolerant, understanding, patient Willful Accepting of the inevitable

Untrustworthy, unreliable, dishonest Trustworthy Withdrawn Outgoing

Instructions for Completion

Table of Flaws

Flaw

Give your best example of this specific flaw in your life.

Provide space for personal reflection and examples.

Review of Assets

Draw on the previous checklist. You do have assets. These are the assets you had before alcohol or drugs became a problem, or that are reappearing now that you are clean and sober.

Asset

Give your best example of this specific asset in your life.

Provide space for personal reflection and examples.

Sex Conduct Checklist

Column 1 Checklist

(We reviewed our sex conduct over the years past. Whom had we hurt?)

- Her, him, family, friends, co-workers, etc.
- Myself with guilt or shame

- Infecting him/her with a sexually transmitted disease
- Involving him/her in legal proceedings
- Embarrassing him/her
- How did I cause the hurt?

Column 2 Checklist

(Where had we been selfish, dishonest, or inconsiderate?)

Selfish

- Using him/her to meet my needs for sex, attention, approval, mothering, or fathering
- Not seeing his/her needs or problems
- Wanting to look good or be liked
- Taking out my emotions on him/her (anger, sadness, etc.)
- Wanting to control him/her
- Wanting special treatment
- Wanting him/her to take care of me
- Wanting more than my share
- Not trying to be a friend

Dishonest (to me or others)

- Leading someone on—saying I care for him/her more than I do because I want sex
- Not admitting my sexual orientation

- Thinking I'm better (grandiosity)
- Being perfectionistic
- Not being clear about my motive (wanting fathering, mothering, approval, or sex)
- Wanting to vent my emotions on or control him/her
- Cheating on him/her

Inconsiderate

- To her, him, family, friends, co-workers, etc.
- Putting others or myself at risk of disease, legal involvement, and embarrassment
- How was I inconsiderate?

Empowerment Step - I make a searching and fearless moral inventory of myself

- Have you had any broken relationships? If so, describe them and how they hurt others or yourself. Describe any grudges, anger, or resentment that you have over these relationships.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Have you ever felt self-righteous? Explain when and the circumstances. Was this justified? Elaborate.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- What events or triggers have caused you to begin your addictive behaviors in the past? Describe situations, feelings, events, food, or people that seem to be a part of your life just

before or during your addictive behaviors.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Have you ever held a grudge? Did you try to get revenge? If so, explain the situation and how it played out, including whether or not someone else was hurt.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe times that you have been oversensitive. Did this ever damage your relationship with others, or were you just trying to keep your own boundaries?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe the faults that you most detest in others. Do you have any of these traits yourself?

Provide space for personal reflection.

Traits That I Despise in Others

Place a checkmark beside any of the following traits that you despise in others. Also check whether you see these traits in yourself.

Trait	In Others	In Myself
Selfishness	[ ]	[ ]
Cowardice	[ ]	[ ]

Dishonesty [ ] [ ]

Fearfulness [ ] [ ]

Controlling [ ] [ ]

Manipulative [ ] [ ]

Intimidating [ ] [ ]

Power-hungry [ ] [ ]

Possessive [ ] [ ]

Prejudiced [ ] [ ]

Overly dependent [ ] [ ]

Procrastinating [ ] [ ]

Judgmental [ ] [ ]

Preoccupied [ ] [ ]

Lying [ ] [ ]

Cheating [ ] [ ]

Intolerant [ ] [ ]

Self-pitying [ ] [ ]

Jealous [ ] [ ]

Insecure [ ] [ ]

Greedy [ ] [ ]

Snobbish [ ] [ ]

Sarcastic [ ] [ ]

Hypercritical [ ] [ ]

Gossip [ ] [ ]

Tightwad [ ] [ ]

Harsh [ ] [ ]

Unforgiving [ ] [ ]

Verbally abusive [ ] [ ]

Physically abusive [ ] [ ]

Sexually abusive [ ] [ ]

Impatient [ ] [ ]

Adulterous [ ] [ ]

Sneaky [ ] [ ]

Ungrateful [ ] [ ]

Cynical [ ] [ ]

Bitter [ ] [ ]

Full of rage [ ] [ ]

Envious [ ] [ ]

Insecure [ ] [ ]

- Have you failed to do things that you KNOW you should have done? If so, then explain in detail.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- What are your fears? How have they caused you difficulty in your life?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe your relationship with your friends, co-workers, or neighbors. Is there something that you wish you could do over again? If so, explain in detail.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe your relationships with your family of origin. Do you have conflicts with any siblings or with your parents? Are you avoiding these matters in your family?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe the earliest memories of your life. Did you share a similar personality with those in your family or were they very different from you? Do you think that these similarities or differences caused problems in your life? If so, explain.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- If you were to describe your family's major themes, what would they be?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe your relationships with your nuclear family (spouse and children). Is there anything that you wish you could erase from this part of your life?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe in detail any major experiences in your life that you believe changed your life forever afterward (good or bad).

Provide space for personal reflection.

- What decisions have you made in your life that made a significant impact? How did you go about making those decisions?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- How much of your life have you used up already? If you drew a timeline of your life, where would you be now?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Put your major experiences and major decisions on a timeline. Is there a pattern of any kind?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- What are you most ashamed of in your life?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Do you see any patterns in your addictive behaviors? If so, explain them in detail.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- What have you done to cover and conceal your addictive behaviors? What other deceptions did this lead to?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- What kind of personality do you exhibit at home? At school? At work? When no one is around?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- What is so shameful in your life that you would not want to tell anyone? Who would you hurt if you told this?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Write a summary of the highlights of this step.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- How would you like to share this step summary? What details would you like to make sure are known? Write these details down in your summary and prepare the summary for presentation in your next step.

Provide space for personal reflection.

- Describe any celebrations or honoring activities that you have done to honor the completion of this step.

Provide space for personal reflection.

The Next Step

Admitting to ourselves and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs is the objective of this step in the Trifecta Program. Admitting our wrongs thoroughly in a manner reminiscent of this will heal us of guilt, indignity, regret, alarm, resentment, animosity, jealousy, and countless other obstructions that may thwart our forward progress in recovery.

Acknowledgment of our wrongs will help us in self-forgiveness, thereby enabling us a safe, protected passage down the path of ongoing recovery. For us to disclose to ourselves and to another human being the precise nature of our wrongs will necessitate an act of proper humility on our part; however, humbling ourselves brings us superior attentiveness and candidness that will unquestionably bring us liberation from the bondage of our past wrongs.

After writing down our personal moral inventory in the previous step, we are now ready to mend our past wounds through confession and humility. This confession process is truly life-giving. Once this act has been accomplished, a new source of guidance and protection will thrive in our journey. All obstructions are set aside from our path, and we obtain complete insight, understanding, and direction from our Higher Empowered Self. We will get more in touch with our spirituality and sense of purpose that will provide us with the additional drive that we need to excel. We cannot stress enough the importance of carrying out this step in our recovery.

You might be very timid and frightened of painstakingly completing this crucial step. It takes a while to gain the nerve to initiate this step, but when you finally admit your wrongs, a sense of relief and pleasure will fill you like never before. It will be a very awe-inspiring occurrence for you, but the act itself isn't as bad as you pictured. For you to sincerely and entirely follow through with this step, you will have to eliminate all negative thoughts from your mind. Tell yourself that completing this step will only generate additional expansion and improvement in your life and in your recovery. You must set aside the false pride that is trying to surface. Quiet your mind while asking yourself for the courage and vigor to put together a thorough confession.

Start admitting your wrongs to yourself, then read your personal inventory while recollecting all corrupt situations that you can remember. Start with your childhood, and then admit your wrongs all the way to the present, while asking for your own forgiveness and mercy. You might not be able to complete that whole procedure in one session, but in due course, tell yourself about every one of your wrongs that you can possibly remember, particularly those wrongs that bring you annoyance, bitterness, guilt, humiliation, and sorrow. After admitting your wrongs to yourself, choose your person to admit your wrongs to. Choose someone that you can trust with this information, and be meticulously open and straightforward; it will be such a relief after this course of action is concluded. It may take pages for you to portray the feelings and events that took place. We cannot stress enough the magnitude of completing this step.

Admitting our wrongs is intended to get them out of our way so that we can start fresh and thus empower ourselves. Until we own up to our wrongdoings, we will not forgive ourselves. It is imperative that our Higher Self grant us the strength and audacity to confess our wrongs so we can further help ourselves on our journey. Other results of admitting our wrongs include the removal of temptation to insensitive feelings from those people that we've mistreated and to encourage us to become humble in nature. Admitting our faults promotes our self-assessment. Admission furthermore ensures our spiritual advancement, which is ultimately the central factor in our positive development in recovery. Forgiveness from those that we've wronged will cure our conscience and allow us to move onward in our quest for progressive recovery, personal growth, and spiritual advancement.

To admit the exact nature of our wrongs, we should include all the aspects of wrongdoings that we've committed, such as our wrongs against people, community wrongdoings, private offenses that recurrently overpower us, detrimental mannerisms, devastating tendencies, persistent faults, infrequent blunders, weaknesses, and all other faults or weaknesses of character that we can summon up. Simply, wrongdoings against people and ourselves—huge wrongs or minor wrongs, intentional wrongs or minute wrongs. Through this process, we remove our guilt, throwing it away into the depths of the sea. This covers our embarrassment and disposes of our liability, leaving us with no more to pay while cleansing us of all unrighteousness.

If we decline to follow through with this step, our unconfessed wrongs will haunt us, resulting in the demise of our body and spirit. We will have to continue paying the penalty of our wrongdoings. We will lack strength and peace of mind, leaving us feeling feeble and depressed and not empowered at all. We will lose all sense of joy and completeness. We will

become perturbed and besieged with the dishonor and guilt caused by our unconfessed wrongdoings.

By completing this step, we gain our own forgiveness, supervision, and strength. We obtain complete forgiveness, clearing our debt from previous wrongs. We become open to receive the blessings of our new empowered life. We receive safe and sound refuge. We gain our higher self's cautious counsel. We receive our own unconditional love and support in our recovery. And, foremost, we choose blissful victory as an alternative to catastrophic demise.

To put the declaration of guilt in practical terms, we should address everyone implicated; avoid ifs, buts, and maybes; declare the precise nature of our wrongs; accept the pain that we've created; endure the effects; alter our conduct; and receive reconciliation. Through these steps, we release the burden that our addiction brought us. We step into the spiritual realm, acquiring the much-needed additional assistance that we need to continue moving ahead in our recovery.

From the familiarity that you will gain from completing this step, you will have learned that facing this step with fear is unnecessary, and trepidation will obstruct your detailed confession. We must be open, candid, and wholehearted when beginning this step. There is no need for reluctance or apprehension because after you complete this step, a feeling of relief and healing will engulf you like never before. This is a life-giving experience that will promote a heightened level of positive intensification in our recovery. Stand strong and upright, and be ready for self-forgiveness. The opportunities for personal and spiritual advancement will be unending. You will become a grateful recovering addict/alcoholic. You will never have had the increased amount of awareness, knowledge, and understanding in your life as you will now, especially after completing this step.

We want to emphasize the immense amount of serenity and freedom that we will receive while working this step. All of the baggage from our past is uncovered for the healing process to commence. At this stage in our recovery, all that is required of us is the confession of our wrongdoings—to ourselves and another human being. As we then let go and await miracles, we are provided the necessary means to move on empowered. In the process, we will acquire a better, more enlightened outlook of ourselves, our life, our purpose, and the direction that we are being guided towards.

Never again does the recovering addict/alcoholic have to continue trying to fill the empty void inside. The tools and knowledge that we receive in the course of working the Trifecta program completely fill that emptiness. All the qualities of true delight and contentment are available to us. This is a major step in our recovery process. Previously listed are all the benefits of working this step and the knowledge essential to thoroughly complete it. Keep it simple, take one day at a time, seize the opportunity, and candidly tread forth in faith, relying on your empowered higher self to supply you with the courage and power necessary to engage in this step. Understand that fear will only stall the thorough process of your empowerment. This will be a major milestone in your recovery, and good luck to all.

I admit to myself and to another human being the exact nature of my wrongs

- After working through this set of step questions, what do you realize about your limitations and capabilities?

Provide space for personal reflection.

- **Describe any person who has helped you to see yourself more clearly

Personal Reflections and Sponsor Exploration

Reflection on Support in Recovery

Describe anyone who has helped you see yourself more clearly and objectively in your recovery journey.

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Ideal Sponsor Qualities

What qualities would you like in a sponsor? How do the potential sponsors on your list measure up to these criteria?

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Trustworthy Support System

Write down the names of the most trustworthy people you know. Do you believe they would be willing or interested in becoming a sponsor for you?

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Sharing Your Journey

Describe your feelings and expectations about sharing this step with another person.

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Safe, Risky, or Bad Choice

List people you might share your story with and whether they are a safe, risky, or poor choice to work through your step.

Person's Name Safe, Risky, or Bad Choice

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Support Selection and Experience

Describe who you have chosen to be your support person and how they reacted when you approached them.

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Reflecting on the Sharing Process

Describe what it was like to share this step. How did you feel before, during, and after the experience? Are you glad you completed it?

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Celebrations and Milestones

Share any celebrations or activities you've done to honor the completion of this step.

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Preparing Your Sober Self for Action

Let's consider the story of a former client, Dave. Once a middle-class executive, he became the number one person on a small-town Ontario list of homeless individuals most likely to die on

the streets. An interventionist from Trifecta Addiction brought Dave to our Muskoka location, placing him under the care of a counselor named Daniel.

Daniel didn't focus on Dave's shortcomings or past mistakes, understanding that healing cannot begin by reopening wounds but rather by recognizing and reinforcing the positives. By focusing on his strengths, Daniel helped Dave tap into his inner resilience and see his potential as a sober individual.

Reinforcing Your Sober Self

Stop Beating Yourself Up

People struggling with addiction are often hard on themselves. We internalize negative judgments from others, which can become barriers to our recovery. The "A" part of ourselves drives us to use substances, creating feelings of misery and stress. Recovery requires recognizing our strengths and giving ourselves credit for progress, however small.

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Becoming Your Own Support

If you don’t have someone to tell you that you’re strong and capable, it’s essential to cultivate that supportive voice within yourself. Learn to see your strengths and avoid self-criticism.

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Starting Small is Okay

No progress is too small. Even small signs of resilience and self-acceptance can be transformative. Remember that even the smallest desire to change can be the start of a meaningful journey toward sobriety.

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Handling Relapse without Self-Blame

When people return from a relapse, they often engage in self-blame. Common statements include, “I’m no good,” or “I’ll never get it.” These thoughts stem from the relapse, and the “A” voice can try to break down self-worth. But remember, **you deserve credit for returning to recovery**.

This workbook’s goal is to help you strengthen your “Sober Self,” to see your resilience and successes, and to stop beating yourself up.

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Recognizing and Reclaiming Your Sober Self

No achievement is too small to build on. The smallest step toward sober living is still a step in the right direction. Over time, these small wins build momentum and encourage further progress.

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Listen for Your Wake-Up Call

For some, the wake-up call to recovery might come from a sudden event or realization. For others, it may be a quiet moment of self-reflection. This wake-up call, however it appears, can motivate you to act.

When did you realize that you needed to change?

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Motivating Yourself to Start

Visualize Your New Life

Imagine yourself free of substances. Picture how you will feel and what you will be doing with more time, energy, and resources. Consider details like where you are, what you're wearing, and who is with you. Write down your vision here.

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Find Something to Laugh About

Laughter can be a powerful tool. It's hard to feel stressed or upset when you're laughing. Take some time to write down things that make you laugh or activities that bring you joy.

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Forgive Yourself for Past Substance Use

Carrying guilt or shame can be a barrier to recovery. Understand that, at the time, you may not have known where substance use would lead. Write down any thoughts or feelings you want to let go of as you move forward.

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Take Control of What You Can Do

Sometimes the first steps to sobriety are about doing what is within your control. Focus on small actions that can move you forward, and list a few here.

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Turn Off Unhelpful Media

Certain media can reinforce negative emotions or glorify substance use. Reducing exposure to stressful or triggering media can help. Consider listing some changes you can make in your media habits here.

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Reframe Negatives into Positives

Instead of viewing sobriety as “quitting,” think of it as gaining freedom. Write down any negative thoughts and try to reframe them into positive perspectives.

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Get Moving: Exercise and Healthy Living

Exercise and good nutrition support a healthier mind and body. Write down some physical activities or dietary changes you’d like to try.

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Prioritize Rest and Quality Sleep

Sleep is crucial for a stable mood and clear thinking. List any habits that may help you improve your sleep routine here.

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Building Resilience Through Trifecta Addiction's Empowerment Principles

Strengthen Your Inner Voice

Think about ways you can strengthen your inner support system, even when things feel difficult. List a few ideas or practices here:

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Embracing Setbacks as Learning Opportunities

Setbacks or relapses are a common part of the recovery journey. How can you use these experiences to reinforce your goals with Trifecta Addiction?

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Celebrating Small Wins

List any recent achievements, no matter how small, and consider how they are moving you toward your goal.

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Tools for Maintaining Sobriety with Trifecta Addiction's Support

Establish a Relapse Prevention Plan

Think about your triggers and how you'll respond to them. Write down some strategies you want to include in your plan.

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Identify Early Warning Signs

What are some signs you've noticed that indicate a slip might happen?

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Develop Coping Strategies

List a few healthy coping strategies that you can turn to when you're feeling stressed, anxious, or tempted.

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Revisit Your Goals Regularly

Checking in on your goals can help you stay focused and motivated. List any goals you're working toward and any adjustments you'd like to make.

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Trifecta Addiction Empowerment Workbook

Personal Reflections and Support Person Exploration

Reflection on Support in Recovery

Describe anyone who has helped you see yourself more clearly and objectively in your recovery journey.

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Ideal Qualities in a Support Person

What qualities would you like in a support person? How do the potential support people on your list measure up to these criteria?

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Trustworthy Support System

Write down the names of the most trustworthy people you know. Do you believe they would be willing or interested in becoming a support person for you?

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Sharing Your Journey

Describe your feelings and expectations about sharing this step with another person.

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Safe, Risky, or Poor Choice

List people you might share your story with and whether they are a safe, risky, or poor choice to work through your step.

Person's Name Safe, Risky, or Poor Choice

Selection and Experience with Support Person

Describe who you have chosen as your support person and how they reacted when you approached them.

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Reflecting on the Sharing Process

Describe what it was like to share this step. How did you feel before, during, and after the experience? Are you glad you completed it?

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Celebrations and Milestones

Share any celebrations or activities you've done to honor the completion of this step.

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PREPARE YOUR SOBER SELF FOR ACTION

Understanding the Physiological Basis of Addiction

Addiction is not solely behavioral or character-based; it has a

profound physiological component. Research on laboratory animals, including a pivotal study from fifty years ago, has demonstrated that introducing a sustained high dose of addictive substances into the bloodstream can induce addiction.

For example, chimpanzees addicted to opium would seek the drug, even positioning themselves for an injection when the cabinet where it was stored was opened. Over time, other animals like monkeys, dogs, and rodents have shown that addiction manifests across species, indicating that it's not just a human experience.

Eliot Gardner, a leading neuroscientist, highlighted that addiction theories grounded solely in human societal factors don't apply to laboratory animals—yet these animals also become addicted to the same substances as humans. Gardner explained:

"This argues compellingly for a profoundly important biological basis for substance abuse."

Addiction in Lab Animals

Researchers have consistently turned healthy animals into addicted ones by introducing high doses of substances into their systems. Within days, these animals become chemically dependent, displaying behaviors such as:

- **Ignoring food and water** in favor of the addictive substance.
- Exhibiting **cravings**, **cue-based relapse behaviors**, and **withdrawal symptoms**.
- Showing a preference for **locations associated with substance use**.

This dependence is even observed in simpler organisms, such as fruit flies and nematodes, providing insights into the mechanisms behind addiction.

Addiction and Brain Chemistry

Although many molecular details of addiction are still under investigation, the core understanding of addiction's roots is well-established. **Chronic substance use changes the brain**, driving addictive behaviors. Addiction is driven by the chemical effects of substances on the brain, creating patterns that reinforce usage.

Dispelling Myths About Addiction

You're Not Defective

A common myth that hinders recovery is the belief that addiction stems from character flaws. Decades of research, including animal studies, disprove this notion. **Addiction results**

from the interaction of addictive substances with brain chemistry, not from unchangeable flaws in character.

Every Personality Type Is Susceptible to Addiction

Another misconception is the idea of an “addictive personality”—a specific personality type that predisposes one to addiction. However, fifty years of studies have failed to identify such a profile. **Addiction is a result of substances’ chemical effects on the brain, not personality**.

We Can’t Change Our Character, But We Can Change Our Actions

While character may be a constant part of who we are, **we can make choices to influence our actions**. By eliminating addictive substances, brain recovery can begin quickly, allowing individuals to address needs and challenges without reliance on substances.

Embrace a Diverse Recovery Approach

Addiction affects individuals from all backgrounds. Recovery programs and support groups reveal that addiction transcends character types, emphasizing that **no one is immune to the physiological effects of addictive substances**.

An Example of Resilience in Recovery

Consider a former Trifecta Addiction client, whom we'll call **Dave**. Once a middle-class business executive, he became known as the top individual on a list of homeless alcoholics in a small Ontario town. An interventionist from Trifecta Addiction found Dave and brought him to the Muskoka facility, placing him under the care of a counselor, **Daniel**.

Daniel didn't focus on Dave's mistakes or shortcomings. Instead, he told Dave:

> "You're a strong, wise man,"

reinforcing positive qualities rather than re-opening wounds. Healing, Daniel understood, begins by **recognizing and strengthening the sober side**.

Reinforcing Your Sober Self

Many individuals struggle with self-judgment, which can push away support and opportunities for change. This section introduces methods to help break through initial paralysis and build the courage necessary for recovery.

Stop Beating Yourself Up

People who use addictive substances are often hard on themselves, internalizing judgments from others. Here, we focus on **building self-compassion**, separating the “A” (Addictive Voice) from the “S” (Sober Self). The “A” voice thrives on misery, while the “S” encourages confidence and growth. Recognizing and celebrating small achievements helps the “S” gain strength.

Write down some positive qualities or achievements you recognize in yourself:

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Becoming Your Own Support

Not everyone has a “Daniel” in their lives. Without external support, it’s crucial to develop an **inner voice of compassion**.

Practice recognizing strengths rather than focusing on self-criticism.

List ways you can practice self-compassion and support yourself:

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Starting Small Is Okay

No progress is too small. Even small signs of resilience and self-acceptance can be transformative. Remember that even the smallest desire to change can be the start of a meaningful journey toward sobriety.

Identify small steps you can take toward your recovery goals:

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Handling Relapse Without Self-Blame

When people return from a relapse, they often engage in self-blame. Common statements include, “I’m no good,” or “I’ll never get it.” These thoughts stem from the relapse, and the “A” voice can try to break down self-worth. But remember, you deserve credit for returning to recovery.

Reflect on any setbacks you’ve experienced and how you can view them as learning opportunities:

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Recognizing and Reclaiming Your Sober Self

No achievement is too small to build on. The smallest step toward sober living is still a step in the right direction. Over time, these small wins build momentum and encourage further progress.

List recent successes or positive changes you've made, no matter how small:

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Listen for Your Wake-Up Call

For some, the wake-up call to recovery might come from a sudden event or realization. For others, it may be a quiet moment of self-reflection. This wake-up call, however it appears, can motivate you to act.

When did you realize that you needed to change? Describe that moment or realization:

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Motivating Yourself to Start

Recovery is a positive act. Here are some strategies to inspire motivation:

Visualize Your New Life

Imagine yourself free of substances. Picture how you will feel and what you will be doing with more time, energy, and resources. Consider details like where you are, what you're wearing, and who is with you.

Write down your vision of a substance-free life:

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Find Something to Laugh About

Laughter can be a powerful tool. It’s hard to feel stressed or upset when you’re laughing.

List things that make you laugh or activities that bring you joy:

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Forgive Yourself for Past Substance Use

Carrying guilt or shame can be a barrier to recovery. Understand that, at the time, you may not have known where substance use would lead.

Write down any thoughts or feelings you want to let go of as you

move forward:

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Take Control of What You Can Do

Sometimes the first steps to sobriety are about doing what is within your control. Focus on small actions that can move you forward.

List actions you can take right now to support your recovery:

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Turn Off Unhelpful Media

Certain media can reinforce negative emotions or glorify substance use. Reducing exposure to stressful or triggering media can help.

Identify media sources you can limit or avoid and suggest alternatives:

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Reframe Negatives into Positives

Instead of viewing sobriety as “quitting,” think of it as **gaining freedom**.

Write down any negative thoughts and reframe them into positive perspectives:

- **Negative Thought:**

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- **Positive Reframe:**

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- **Negative Thought:**

.....

- **Positive Reframe:**

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Get Moving: Exercise and Healthy Living

Exercise and good nutrition support a healthier mind and body.

List physical activities or dietary changes you’d like to try:

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Prioritize Rest and Quality Sleep

Sleep is crucial for a stable mood and clear thinking.

List habits that may help you improve your sleep routine:

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Connect and Communicate

Open communication with supportive people enhances your outlook.

Who can you reach out to for support or connection?

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Believe in Yourself

Focus on your strengths and envision the **“better you”**.

Write affirmations or positive statements about yourself:

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Building Resilience Through Trifecta Addiction’s Empowerment Principles

Building resilience is key to sustainable change. The tools and principles here aim to help you stay engaged in recovery.

Strengthen Your Inner Voice

Think about ways you can strengthen your inner support system, even when things feel difficult.

List practices or habits that reinforce your inner strength:

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Embracing Setbacks as Learning Opportunities

Setbacks or relapses are a common part of the recovery journey.

How can you use these experiences to reinforce your goals with Trifecta Addiction?

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Celebrating Small Wins

Recognizing and celebrating achievements, no matter how small, can boost motivation.

List recent achievements and how they contribute to your recovery:

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Tools for Maintaining Sobriety with Trifecta

Addiction’s Support

Establish a Relapse Prevention Plan

Think about your triggers and how you’ll respond to them.

Write down strategies you want to include in your plan:

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Identify Early Warning Signs

Being aware of early signs can help you take action before a slip occurs.

What are some signs you’ve noticed that indicate a slip might

happen?

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Develop Coping Strategies

Healthy coping strategies are essential for managing stress and temptation.

List coping methods you can use when facing challenges:

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Revisit Your Goals Regularly

Checking in on your goals can help you stay focused and motivated.

List your current goals and any adjustments you'd like to make:

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Trigger Inventory

We all know that a variety of experiences, situations, and conditions can trigger a powerful **craving** or **urge** to use. This inventory has been developed to help identify our own personal triggers and to help plan for these trigger situations. There are two parts to this inventory. Part one is identifying triggers, and part two is to develop a working plan to cope with cravings and urges.

Part One: Identifying Triggers

This inventory consists of a list of situations and specific cues which might trigger cravings and urges. As you complete this inventory, please check all that apply to you.

Social Pressure and Romance

- Parties with alcohol or drug use
- Clubbing
- Being offered your drug of choice
- Seeking romance
- Seeking sex
- Having sex
- “Breaking up”

- Bar hopping
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Mood States

- Stress
- Anxiety
- Depression
- Loneliness
- Frustration
- Disappointment
- Conflict with others
- Guilt
- Shame
- Boredom
- Low self-esteem
- Feeling powerful
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Work-Related Triggers

- Going to work
- Leaving work
- Break time
- Payday
- Peer pressure at work
- Co-workers using
- Drugs or alcohol available at work
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Celebrations

- Weekends
- Having a good day
- Winning at some activity
- Weddings, birthdays, and celebrations
- Getting good news
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Media Triggers

- Certain music
- Television shows
- News reports about drugs and alcohol
- Movies where actors use
- Concerts
- Alcohol and drug advertisements
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Physical Conditions

- Fatigue
- Pain
- Insomnia
- Feeling sick
- Hunger
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

People, Places, and Things

- Places where you have used

- People you have used with
- Your dealers
- Driving by places you have used
- People using around you
- Paraphernalia
- Phone calls from old friends
- Peer pressure
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Using Other Drugs

- Alcohol
- Pills
- Tranquilizers
- Stimulants
- Opiates
- Marijuana
- Inhalants
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Recreational Activities

- Sports
- Watching television
- Exercising
- Gambling
- Boating
- Fishing
- Golfing
- **Other:** _____
- **Other:** _____

Miscellaneous

- Drug dreams
- Free time
- Smells
- Certain clothes
- Isolating yourself
- Self-pity
- **Other:** _____

- **Other: _____**

Thank you for your work so far. Now, please go back and determine which situation is the biggest problem area for you. Adding up all the checks in the warning sign column should give you an idea which situation is the biggest problem for you. Place a number 1 next to the biggest situation problem area. Then do this again for the second biggest problem area and continue until you have ranked your top five problem areas.

Part Two: Developing a Working Plan

Now you will have the opportunity to develop a work plan for these triggers. By preparing yourself to deal with these triggers and cravings before they occur, you can personally exert control over the likelihood of your relapsing.

Trigger Work Plan

1. The worst trigger situation for me is:

Warning Signs:

……

My Coping Strategies:

.....
.....

2. The second worst trigger situation for me is:

Warning Signs:

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.....

My Coping Strategies:

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3. The third worst trigger situation for me is:

Warning Signs:

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My Coping Strategies:

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4. The fourth worst trigger situation for me is:

Warning Signs:

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.....

My Coping Strategies:

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.....

5. The fifth worst trigger situation for me is:

Warning Signs:

.....
.....

My Coping Strategies:

.....
.....

YOU HAVE POWER OVER THESE CRAVINGS & URGES AND CAN OVERCOME THESE OBSTACLES! WE ARE EMPOWERED ON THIS NEXT PHASE OF OUR LIFE.

Defense Mechanisms

When we are deep into our addiction, we don't give a lot of thought to what we are doing in any setting. Our energies focus on doing "whatever it takes" to keep our supply safe. In the process of getting what we want, we use "tricks" or behaviors that have become habits to us. In recovery language, these tricks are our defense mechanisms. We use them to control our environment, to get our way, to get rid of people who "make us sick." In order to recover, we need to begin to recognize these bad habits, accept that we use them on each other, and look for alternative ways to meet our needs.

This assignment has 40 of the most frequently used defense mechanisms and a description of what each means. These defense mechanisms are divided into four large categories which reflect how we use them:

1. Avoiding Consequences
2. Avoiding People
3. Avoiding Honesty
4. Getting Even

Instructions:

Using a notebook or the space provided, and numbering each one, write the name of the defense mechanism, and then give an example or explanation about how you used that particular "trick" (behavior) to get your way when you were using. Be sure to give a lot of thought to your answers.

Avoiding Consequences

1. **Alibing** - Pretending you had nothing to do with an event to avoid acting appropriately or taking responsibility for your actions.

Your Example:

.....

2. **Blaming** - Placing fault on other people to avoid accepting self-responsibility.

Your Example:

.....

3. **Changing the Subject** - Avoiding the problem by changing the topic.

Your Example:

.....

4. **Cussing** - Using profanity to avoid the true issue.

Your Example:

.....

5. **Discounting** - Putting down or degrading another to avoid hearing or accepting that what the person is saying may be true.

Your Example:

.....

6. **Excusing** - Pretending that an outcome couldn't be avoided and that you weren't responsible.

Your Example:

.....

7. **Explaining** - Giving reasons for behavior to avoid self-responsibility.

Your Example:

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8. **Flattery** - Over-complimenting another person to get what we want.

Your Example:

.....

9. **Humor** - Making light or a joke about something serious to avoid the real issue.

Your Example:

.....

10. **Intellectualizing** - Using scientific reasons to justify behaviors and avoid responsibilities.

Your Example:

.....

11. **Justifying** - “Proving” you are “right” to avoid responsibility for what you did.

Your Example:

.....

12. **Minimizing** - Making something smaller or less important than it really is.

Your Example:

.....

13. **Omitting** - “Forgetting” to mention key information to

avoid taking responsibility.

Your Example:

.....

14. **Rationalizing** - Making assumptions to avoid facing the truth.

Your Example:

.....

15. **Squealing** - “Telling” on someone to take the focus off yourself and avoid consequences.

Your Example:

.....

16. **Attacking** - Aggressively, verbally, or physically assaulting another to avoid examining behaviors that actually belong to you.

Your Example:

.....

(Continue with the remaining defense mechanisms in the same format.)

Early Coping Strategies

The first few weeks after cutting down or stopping substance use can be a difficult time. Some people compare their substance to a best friend or a lover and can feel sadness and grief without it.

There are, however, some important things you can do right away to help prevent a relapse back to problem-using behavior. Try out as many of the following suggestions as you can. The more action you can take, the easier it will be to keep to your substance use goal during this early time in your recovery:

- **Throw out alcohol, other drugs, and paraphernalia.** If this is difficult for you, let a supportive non-using friend help you.
- **Break off all contact with people who drink heavily or use other drugs, and with dealers.** This can be done by clearly telling these people that you don't want any further contact with them. If you are concerned about your safety, discuss your plans with a professional. Do not put yourself at risk of being harmed.
- **If you live in an area with a lot of drug activity, explore whether you can stay with supportive friends or family members for a while.** Consider moving to a more substance-free environment and do not tell drinking buddies, friends who use other drugs, or dealers where you have moved.
- **Change your telephone number.** Throw out contact numbers of dealers.
- **Have checks automatically deposited into your bank account.** Throw out 24-hour cash cards. Have someone hold onto your money for you.

- **Try a new drug-free activity.**
- **Give self-help groups a try.** This means trying out a number of different types and locations of meetings so that you can make an informed decision about whether there is a self-help group that is right for you.
- **Talk to supportive friends, family, or health professionals about situations that are difficult for you.**
- **Tell supportive friends (those who will not encourage you to use alcohol or other drugs) that you are no longer using substances.**

Practice Exercise

Now come up with your own plan to help you cope in early recovery.

1. **What high-risk people do you need to avoid at this time?**

.....

2. **What high-risk places do you need to avoid at this time?**

.....

3. **What high-risk things (e.g., drug paraphernalia, bottles) do you need to throw out or avoid at this time?**

.....

4. **What are some safe activities that you can get involved in now?**

.....

5. **Where can you seek support, or who can give you support?**

.....

Effective Problem Solving

"The problems that exist in the world cannot be solved by the level of thinking that created them." —Albert Einstein

Problem-solving is an essential skill in recovery. Use the following steps to approach challenges:

Six Steps to Successful Problem Solving

1) Define Exactly What the Problem Is

Make sure the problem is concrete and, if necessary, broken down into several sub-problems.

My problem is:

.....

2) Brainstorm Options to Deal with the Problem

Remember—no criticism allowed—be adventurous!

Possible solutions:

- .....
- .....
- .....
- .....

3) Choose the Best Option(s) by Examining the Pros and Cons

Which solution will work best?

Pros and cons of each solution:

- **Solution 1:** Pros: ..... Cons: .....
- **Solution 2:** Pros: ..... Cons: .....
- **Solution 3:** Pros: ..... Cons: .....

4) Generate a Detailed Action Plan

Plan the “when,” “where,” “how,” and “with whom” of the selected solution.

What’s my plan?

.....
.....

5) Put the Plan into Action

Role-play or mentally rehearse the plan and then actually carry it out.

6) Evaluate the Results to See How Well the Selected Solution Worked

If the solution didn’t work, go back to Stage 3 and try again.

Practice Sheet: Problem-Solving

Stage 1: My problem is:

.....

Stage 2: Brainstorm possible solutions:

- .....
- .....
- .....

Stage 3: Pros and cons of each solution:

- **Solution 1:** Pros: ..... Cons: .....
- **Solution 2:** Pros: ..... Cons: .....
- **Solution 3:** Pros: ..... Cons: .....

And the winner is:

……
……

Stage 4: What's my plan?

- **How?** ……
- **When?** ……
- **With whom?** ……

Stage 5: Put the plan into action.

Stage 6: How did it work?

……
……

Forgiveness

Forgiveness is an essential part of creating health and moving forward in recovery.

Definition of Forgiveness

Dictionary Definition:

- **Forgiveness:** To cease to feel angry or resentful towards a person or about an offense.
- **To Pardon:** The remission of consequences.

Steps to Forgiveness

Like recovery, forgiveness is a process, not an event. The only requirement is willingness to change the thoughts in your own mind.

The Stages of Forgiving:

1. **Hurt** - Acknowledge the pain you feel.
2. **Anger or Hate** - Allow yourself to feel these emotions fully.
3. **Deciding to Forgive** - Make a conscious choice to forgive.
4. **Healing** - Begin to see the person who hurt you in a new light.
5. **Coming Together** (Optional) - If appropriate, invite the person back into your life.

Exercises

1. Make a List of People Who Might Be Forgiven

Include people you presently feel should never be forgiven.

2. Write a Letter

Write a letter to people that you may not wish to deal with face to face. Read this letter aloud to a supportive person, then either rip the letter up or burn it, releasing the judgments and feelings that you hold.

3. Practice a Meditation Around Loving-Kindness

Begin with yourself and gradually expand your focus to others.

Final Commitment to Your Recovery Program

My Empowerment Recovery Program

I, _____, am willing to commit myself to the recovery program as outlined below.

- **Minimum number of AA meetings per week: _____**

- **Minimum number of NA meetings per week: _____**

What do you plan to do daily for your recovery:

1. .....
.....
2. .....
.....
3. .....
.....
4. .....
.....

Additional commitments to recovery:

.....
.....

Do you currently belong to a Home Group? Yes / No

- **Which Group? _____**
- **Are You Active?** (business meetings, greeting, etc.) Yes / No

Do You Have a Support Person? Yes / No

- **Name: _____**

Signed: _____ Dated: _____

Counselor: _____

Weekend Plan

Saturday, Sunday

- **Emotionally:** .....
- **Physically:** .....
- **Mentally:** .....
- **Socially:** .....
- **Reflectively:** .....
- **Spiritually:** .....

Who will I spend time with that is supportive:

.....
.....

What do I need to do to avoid regrets:

.....

Who will I call and what will I do if I am triggered:

.....

This Is Your Journey

Remember, your journey is personal, and every step forward is a victory. Use this workbook as a tool to reflect, plan, and empower yourself on the path to recovery.

Notes

Feel free to use the space below for any additional thoughts or reflections:

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

Thank you for taking the time to engage with this workbook. Your commitment to your recovery is commendable. Always remember that support is available, and you are not alone on this journey.

Trifecta Addiction Empowerment Workbook

Empowering you to build a healthier, substance-free life.

Contact Information

If you need assistance or support, please reach out to Trifecta Addiction:

- **Phone:** 587-577-3554
- **Email:** info@trifectaaddictionservices.com

- **Website:** www.trifectaaddictionservices.com